GAMING IS NO CHILD'S PLAY

››› ROLES OF A GAME DESIGNER

A game designer is at the beginning of the creation process of a game, at the middle of the process for "building" it and at the end to ensure the quality of this entertaining experience we call a video game - all at the same time. We game designers, have different roles depending on the phase in which the game we are working on is at.

››› CONCEPTUALIZATION PHASE

We the designers, create what we call the "Game Concept Document", a small document that explains briefly what the game is about, who is the target (age & sex of the player) and why this game is worth investing millions in. This document is used to sell the future game to possible investors as to the team that will create it. Once a deal is secured, the game starts its next phase.

››› THE PRE-PRODUCTION PHASE

During this phase, the game designers write the Game Design Document that describes everything, right from the way the player will start the game to the most complicated rule to be coded by the programmers. From the text that will be displayed on the buttons in the menu pages to the dialogues between characters, and the epic story the character will experience to the tedious list of items the player will be able to buy in a shop (with price/ stats/ description etc.).

Everything needs to be thought of, discussed with whoever has input on it (it can be another designer, a programmer or an artist depending of the topic) and written down in that bible document - the game design document (which is usually a list of smaller documents where it's easier to seek the relevant information you are looking for than a 5000 pages unreadable document). That's the biggest job of the game designers. From this document, all other departments (art/sound/programming) will extract their own specific bible (Technical design document for the programmers, Sound design document for the sound designers and Artistic Design document for the artists).When the pre-production phase is over we start with the production.

››› THE PRODUCTION PHASE

That's where the thinking time is over and the time to act starts. During this part, some game designers change their role to Level Designers. A game designer thinks and does things at a Macro level in a game (i.e. : "what happen when the character's health reaches 0") while a level designer is in charge of creating the game by creating its levels and is needed to answer more ground based questions (i.e.: "I need to ambush the player, where can I hide my monsters ?"). Not only does the Level designer follow the rules and the guidelines written in the Game Design Document but he also writes his own document : the Level Design Document, having very few specifications where things related only to his level will be explained.

Usually the level designer also needs to create the rough level in 3D using cubes or already made assets in order to script the events, place enemies and challenges and play it to make sure the level he is creating is fun. The Level designer works closely with the artists that will create the set of his level. He also needs to work with the gameplay programmers to make sure the gameplays designed by him work well, as designed.

During this production phase the Game Designers still work on the design to adapt and do the needed compromises between unexpected technically undoable features and gameplay.

››› FINE TUNING / POLISHING

During this phase, everyone in the team (programmers /designers /artists / sound designers etc.) fixes the bugs found by the quality assurance department.

››› WHAT'S TAUGHT AT DSK SUPINFOGAME?

The name of the curriculum is 'Game Design & Production Management'.

The students don't have any choice. They all have the same course in both management and design in order to become either a game designer or a project manager. By game designer we mean either game or level designer.

Because both - a game designer and a project manager or producer need strong communication skills we train them in all forms of communication (writing, video report, power point presentations, etc.) and also in the usage of common tools used for communication - ranging from the most basic steps like using outlook to send an email to the most complex ones like creating a video using Adobe Premiere or Microsoft PowerPoint / Word / Excel etc.

Because you don't need a specific profile in order to become a game designer, beside a strong motivation and a little bit of creativity, we also train our students in using the other departments' tools. That means, we train them in programming and modeling in 3D. Here, we are not forming programmers or animators, but the more they know those tools, the easier it is for them to be able to talk on the same level with the other people in the team.

Game designers often act as universal translators between programmers and artists. They also need to explain correctly to the artists what they want. Same is with the programmers. The more they understand other people's work; the easier it is for them to make themselves understood.

Also, the small skill they get from 3D modeling and programming will be useful for them when they'll be level designers, using a level editor to roughly build the 3D layout of their level or using the script language logic to code an interactive event in the same level.

We also train them a lot in basic things like what games are - not only video games, but all kind of games. Gaming is a very old hobby for man, and by having a strong knowledge in the structures that all games share, they will improve their skill at creating games appealing to more players.

We also train them in analyzing other arts like photography, movies and even video games. Inspiration comes from your past experiences, your knowledge, the books you read, the movies you watch, the games you play etc. But you need to be able to get the relevant information from those media in order to be able to adapt, modify and use it for your game.

We also train them to get self-trained. I mean, the curriculum is 4 years long and to be honest, we can't say what technology will be used in 4 years. So instead of having them to blindly learn how to use a specific tool, we train the students to understand how all similar tools work. Like that they do not feel lost while using a new world builder for the first time since all of them roughly share the same logic.

Despite this, we train them with the latest technology used by our friends in the video game studios and we make sure that we stay up to date with the industry by going to major industry events and talking to people. We believe in keeping strong connections with the industry as a key for a successful professional curriculum. We keep tuning the teaching content on par with the industry needs.

During 4 years here, the students will create a board game prototype, will write an adventure book, will shoot a video report, create a Machinima movie, create a real full game and countless small one week projects etc. The students also have to do a minimum of 2 internships in video games studios.

When exiting the school, the students will have true work experiences in every aspect of the job of a game designer.

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SUPINFOGAME's curriculum is drawn up by an educational team consisting largely of working professionals from the world over:

- Knowledge and expertise passed on by qualified professionals.
- Lectures followed up by practical exercises (over 1000 hours a year).
- Conferences and talks by stars from the video game industry.
- Learning about commonly used software packages.
- Intensive project work.
- Continuous assessment and quarterly exams.
- Insistence on quality: a minimum overall score of 12/20 is required to qualify for the next level of the course.
- Public presentation of end–of–course project / work in front of a panel comprising industry professionals.
- Compulsory placements during the higher education course (initial work experience).
- A joint venture with Supinfocom Group, France, the world leaders.
- Full time faculty from France and other parts of Europe
- State-of-the-art campus spread over 20 acres.